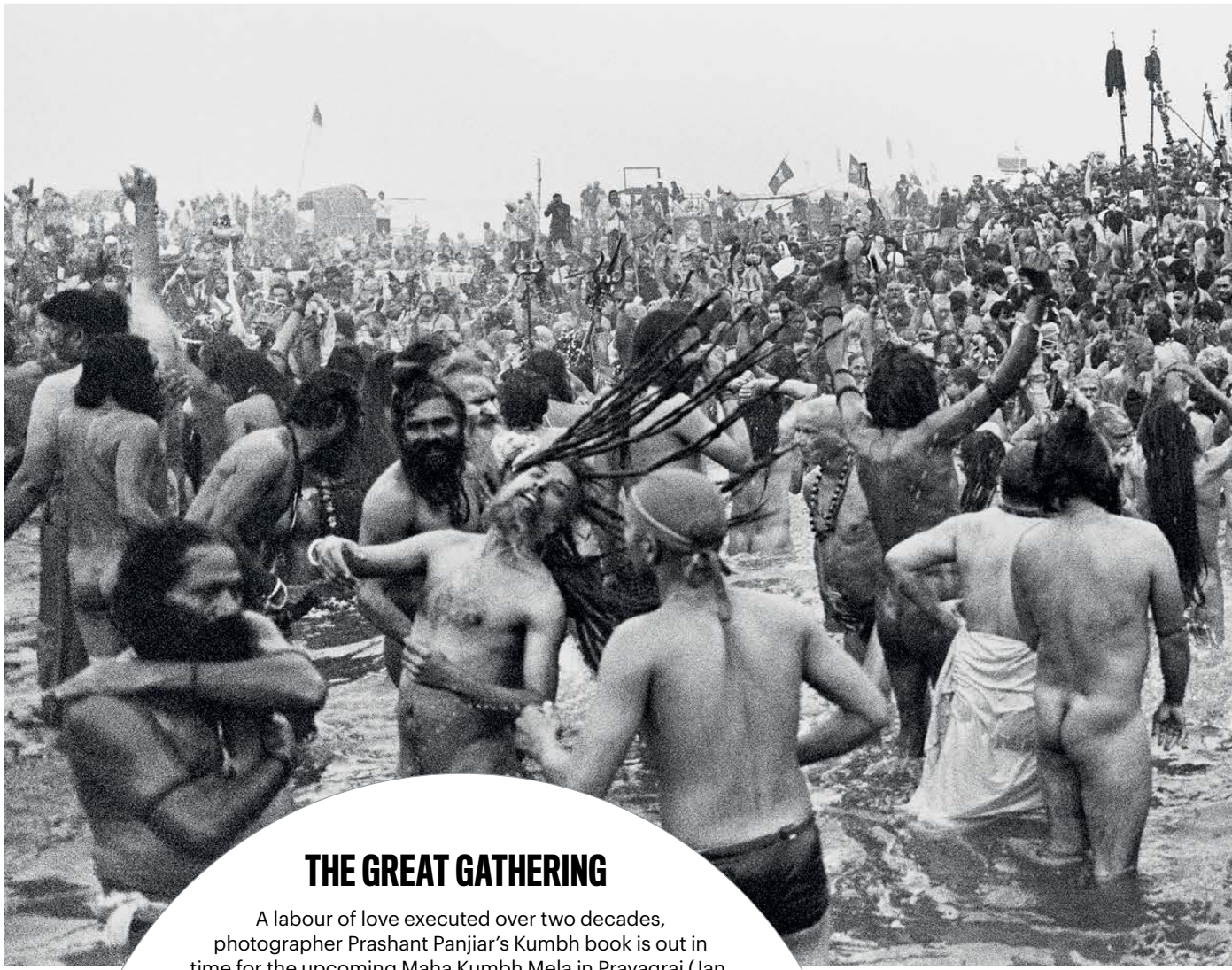


THE GREAT GATHERING

A labour of love executed over two decades, photographer Prashant Panjiar's Kumbh book is out in time for the upcoming Maha Kumbh Mela in Prayagraj (Jan. 13-Feb. 26, 2025). Panjiar first went to the Kumbh in 2001. "The idea of an ancient almost primordial mega event in a 'futuristic' connected global world was extremely seductive. I came back from the festival with many images that lived up to the image of it being the 'greatest show on earth'," he says. Panjiar returned for the Ardh Kumbhs of 2007 and 2019 and the Maha Kumbh of 2013.

The result is a unique, large-format book featuring 48 black-and-white panoramic photographs, shot entirely on film. While Panjiar used a Widelux camera borrowed from Raghu Rai during the 2001 Kumbh, for the subsequent melas he worked with a Hasselblad XPan. With loose-leaf pages tied with a thread along the spine, the book is designed such that its pages can be removed and framed to hang as art prints.

Amongst the Believers: The Kumbh Mela at Prayag showcases the incredible cultural continuum of the world's largest public gathering and collective act of faith. "On reaching the river, after navigating through the crush of millions, an ordinary pilgrim's final prayer is deeply personal and very powerful. You do not have to be a Hindu, or even a believer, to be moved by the beauty of this communion," says Panjiar.

Amit Dixit

